

Providing Examples

Video Link: [Providing Examples](#)

Providing examples in your prompts is one of the most effective prompt engineering techniques you'll use. This approach, known as "one-shot" or "multi-shot" prompting, involves giving Claude sample input/output pairs to guide its responses.

How Examples Work

Let's look at a sentiment analysis example. Say you want Claude to categorize whether a tweet is positive or negative:

Provide Examples

Give Claude sample input/output pairs

- Useful for capturing corner cases or complex output formats
- "One-Shot": provide a single example
- "Multi-Shot": provide multiple examples
- Highly recommend combining with XML tags for structure!

ANTHROPIC

Categorize the sentiment of the below tweet:

<input_tweet>

Yeah, sure, that was the best movie I've seen since 'Plan 9 from Outer Space'

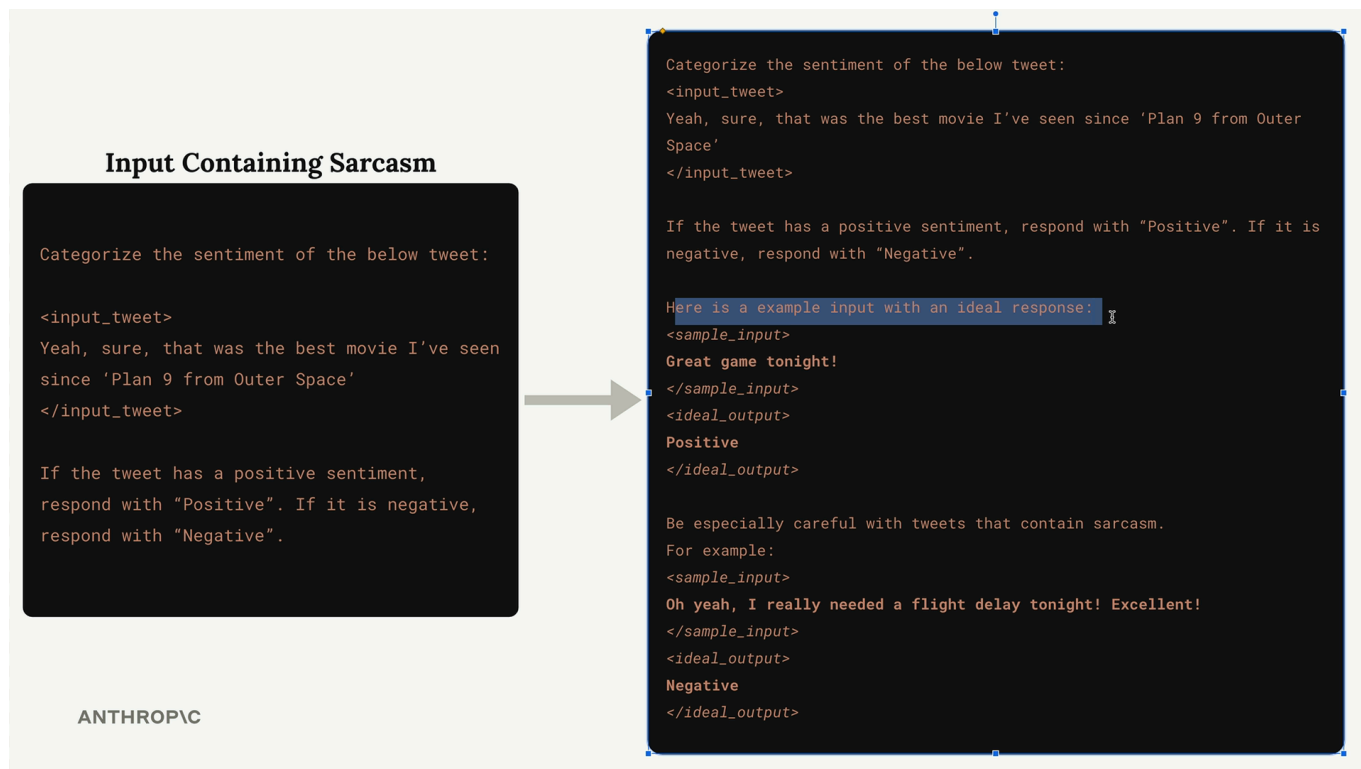
</input_tweet>

If the tweet has a positive sentiment, respond with "Positive". If it is negative, respond with "Negative".

The challenge here is sarcasm. A tweet like "Yeah, sure, that was the best movie I've seen since 'Plan 9 from Outer Space'" appears positive on the surface, but it's actually sarcastic and negative (Plan 9 is famously one of the worst movies ever made).

Adding Examples to Handle Corner Cases

To solve this, you can add examples that show Claude how to handle tricky cases:



The improved prompt includes:

- A clear positive example: "Great game tonight!" → "Positive"
- A sarcastic example: "Oh yeah, I really needed a flight delay tonight! Excellent!" → "Negative"
- Context explaining why sarcasm should be treated carefully

Notice how the examples are wrapped in XML tags like `<sample_input>` and `<ideal_output>`. This structure makes it crystal clear to Claude what each part represents.

When to Use Examples

Examples are particularly useful for:

- Capturing corner cases or edge scenarios
- Defining complex output formats (like specific JSON structures)
- Showing the exact style or tone you want
- Demonstrating how to handle ambiguous inputs

One-Shot vs Multi-Shot

One-Shot: Provide a single example to establish the pattern

Multi-Shot: Provide multiple examples to cover different scenarios

Use multi-shot when you need to handle various edge cases or want to show different types of valid responses.

Finding Good Examples from Evaluations

When running prompt evaluations, look for your highest-scoring outputs to use as examples:

Athlete with high cholesterol, female, 70kg, heart-healthy fats	height: 170 weight: 70 goal: Maintain fitness and improve cholesterol levels restrictions: High cholesterol	- The meal plan is a 1-day plan. - The meal plan is concise and easy to follow. - The meal plan is suitable for a female athlete weighing 70kg. - The meal plan includes meals and snacks. - The meal plan incorporates heart-healthy fats (e.g., avocado, nuts, olive oil). - The meal plan is low in saturated and trans fats. - The meal plan is moderate in protein. - The meal plan includes fiber-rich foods (e.g., whole grains, fruits, vegetables). - The meal plan avoids excessive cholesterol-rich foods (e.g., egg yolks, red meat). - The meal plan provides approximately 2000-2500 calories (adjust based on activity level). - Example acceptable meal: Breakfast - Oatmeal with berries and nuts. Lunch - Salad with grilled chicken or fish and avocado. Dinner - Baked salmon with roasted vegetables and quinoa. Snacks - Apple with almond butter, Greek yogurt. - The plan is presented in a clear and organized format (e.g., bullet points or a table). - The output is less than 400 tokens.	<pre> * Carbs: ~60g * **Afternoon Snack (4:00 PM):** Apple (1 medium) with 30g peanut butter. * Calories: ~300 * Protein: ~10g * Fat: ~20g * Carbs: ~25g * **Dinner (7:00 PM):** Salmon (120g) with 150g sweet potato and 100g broccoli. * Calories: ~600 * Protein: ~25g * Fat: ~15g * Carbs: ~112g </pre> Here is a one-day meal plan for an athlete aiming to maintain fitness and improve cholesterol levels: Calorie Target: Approximately 2500 calories Macronutrient Breakdown: Protein (140g), Fat (70g), Carbs (340g) Meal Plan: Breakfast (7:00 AM): Oatmeal (80g dry weight) with berries (100g) and walnuts (15g). Skim milk (240g). Protein: 15g, Fat: 15g, Carbs: 60g Mid-Morning Snack (10:00 AM): Apple (150g) with almond butter (30g). Protein: 7g, Fat: 18g, Carbs: 25g Lunch (1:00 PM): Grilled chicken breast (120g) salad with mixed greens (150g), cucumber (50g), tomato (50g), and a light vinaigrette dressing (30g). Whole wheat bread (60g). Protein: 40g, Fat: 15g, Carbs: 70g Afternoon Snack (4:00 PM): Greek yogurt (170g, non-fat) with a banana (120g). Protein: 20g, Fat: 0g, Carbs: 40g Dinner (7:00 PM): Baked salmon (140g) with steamed broccoli (200g) and quinoa (75g dry weight). Protein: 40g, Fat: 20g, Carbs: 80g Evening Snack (9:00 PM): Small handful of almonds (20g). Protein: 8g, Fat: 12g, Carbs: 15g This meal plan prioritizes lean protein sources, whole grains, fruits, and vegetables, while limiting saturated and trans fats to support healthy cholesterol levels.	10 The meal plan is well-structured, provides detailed information on food choices and quantities, and aligns with the athlete's goals and restrictions. It meets all the specified criteria.
Athlete seeking a post-race recovery meal plan, female, 55kg	height: 165 weight: 55 goal: Post-race recovery meal	- Provides a 1-day meal plan including breakfast, lunch, dinner, and at least two snacks. - Meal plan emphasizes carbohydrate replenishment for glycogen restoration (aim for approximately 8-10g of carbs per kg of body	Here is a post-race recovery meal plan for a 55kg female endurance athlete, aiming for approximately 2500 calories with a focus on carbohydrate replenishment and muscle repair.	8 The meal plan is well-structured and provides a good balance of macronutrients for post-

Find responses that scored 10 (or your highest available score) and use those input/output pairs as examples in your prompt. This helps Claude understand what "perfect" output looks like for your specific use case.

Adding Context to Examples

Don't just provide the input/output pair - explain why the output is good:

```
<ideal_output>
[Your example output here]
</ideal_output>
```

This example is well-structured, provides detailed information on food choices and quantities, and aligns with the athlete's goals and restrictions.

This additional context helps Claude understand the reasoning behind good responses, not just the format.

Best Practices

- Always use XML tags to structure your examples clearly
- Be explicit about what you're showing: "Here is an example input with an ideal response"
- Include examples that address your most common failure cases
- Explain why your example outputs are considered ideal
- Keep examples relevant to your specific task

Examples are especially powerful because they show rather than tell. Instead of trying to describe exactly what you want in words, you demonstrate it directly. This makes your prompts much more reliable and helps Claude understand subtle requirements that might be hard to express in instructions alone.